

RITIK KHANTWAL



RECOVERY SYSTEM 03

Fixing Your Sleep Schedule

A 14-day reset for professionals who fall asleep at 1:30am, wake at 7, and run the whole day on coffee and adrenaline.

Ritik Khantwal

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You don't have insomnia. You have a schedule.

Most Indian professionals sleeping badly aren't clinically disordered. They've built a day that makes good sleep chemically impossible — and then blamed themselves for it.

Three things decide when you fall asleep: the light your eyes have seen, when your last caffeine was, and how much unfinished mental work you carry into bed. Fix those three and the falling-asleep part stops being a fight. Everything below is built around that.

The four leaks

Leak	What it does	The fix
4pm chai or coffee	Caffeine has a 5–6 hour half-life. A 4pm cup is still 25% active at midnight.	Caffeine curfew at 2pm. Non-negotiable.
No morning daylight	Cab to office, basement parking, AC floor. Your body never gets the signal that the day started.	10 minutes of outdoor light before 9am.
Bright screens at 11pm	Suppresses melatonin and pushes your sleep window later every night.	Screens dimmed and phone out of the bedroom 45 minutes before bed.
Open mental loops	You lie down and the brain finally gets quiet enough to run tomorrow's to-do list.	A five-minute written brain-dump at 9:30pm.

ANCHOR FIRST

Do not try to fall asleep earlier. Fix your **wake time** first and keep it identical for 14 days — including Saturday and Sunday. Bedtime follows wake time. Never the reverse.

The 14-day reset

Days 1–3 — Set the anchor

- Pick a wake time you can hold seven days a week. Most professionals land on **6:45am**.
- Alarm across the room. Phone charges outside the bedroom.
- Within 20 minutes of waking: **outside, no sunglasses, 10 minutes**. Balcony, terrace, walk to the tea stall. This is the highest-leverage action in the whole guide.
- You will be tired. That is the mechanism working, not a sign it's failing.

Days 4–7 — Cut the interference

- Caffeine curfew: 2pm. If you need the 4pm ritual, switch to green tea, then to plain chai without caffeine.
- Last heavy meal 2.5 hours before bed. Late dinner is India's biggest sleep-quality tax.
- Alcohol drops deep sleep by up to 20%. Two drinks maximum, finished 3 hours before bed.
- Bedroom at 22–24°C. Cooler than you think you want.

Days 8–14 — Build the runway

Sleep needs a landing approach, not an emergency stop. Ninety minutes, three stages:

Time	Stage	What you do
9:30pm	Close the loops	Five minutes, pen and paper: tomorrow's three priorities and anything nagging at you. Out of the head, onto the page.
10:00pm	Dim down	Overhead lights off, lamps on. Laptop shut. Phone on charge outside the room.
10:30pm	Wind down	Shower, stretch, read fiction on paper. Boring is the point.
11:00pm	Lights out	Cool, dark, quiet. Same time every night.

IF YOU WAKE AT 3AM

Don't check the time and don't check the phone. If you're still awake after 20 minutes, get out of bed, sit in dim light with a book until you feel sleepy, then return. Lying in bed frustrated teaches your brain that bed is a place for being awake.

Handling the real world

Late-night calls

A 10:30pm US call is unavoidable in Indian corporate life. Dim the screen, use warm room light, and take the call standing or walking. End with the 9:30pm brain-dump ritual compressed to two minutes.

Weekend drift

Sleeping until 11am on Sunday gives you jet lag on Monday without leaving the city. Cap the weekend lie-in at **60 minutes** past your weekday wake time.

Travel and red-eyes

Get morning light in the new city on arrival day. It resets you two to three times faster than waiting it out. Skip the arrival-day nap after 3pm.

Naps

Allowed, but 20 minutes maximum and never after 3pm. A 90-minute afternoon nap is borrowing directly from tonight.

What good looks like by day 14

- You fall asleep within **15–20 minutes** instead of 45–90
- You wake before the alarm at least twice a week
- The 4pm crash is noticeably smaller
- You need one coffee, not three

Daily tracker

- ☐ Woke at anchor time
- ☐ 10 minutes outdoor light before 9am
- ☐ No caffeine after 2pm
- ☐ Phone out of bedroom
- ☐ Lights out within 30 minutes of target

One honest caveat

If you snore heavily, wake gasping, or feel exhausted after 8 full hours for weeks, this is a plan for schedules — not for sleep apnoea. See a doctor and get a sleep study. It's more common in Indian men than most realise, and it's very treatable.